

Literature Review: A Greener Future Recruitment Document

Volunteer recruitment and retention require understanding why people choose to volunteer, what motivates their involvement, and which strategies work best for different non-profit organizations.

According to a study published in *Science Direct* by Neely and colleagues (2021), volunteer recruitment decisions are shaped by internal (the desire to help others, gaining new skills) as well as external factors (volunteering for school credit or for volunteer hours).

The study also introduces a process model explaining how initial interest, commitment, and retention interact. Initial interest usually comes from personal values and external factors, while commitment and retention depend on volunteer expectations, individual goals, and sense of contribution (Neely et al., 2021). This emphasizes why volunteering should focus on attracting people's attention by making it clear why involvement matters.

From a human resources (HR) perspective, the study shows that recruitment and retention must be adapted to the unpaid role whereby traditional salaries are not offered (Neely et al., 2021). This means that focusing on meaningful communication and providing the best experience possible is very important (Neely et al., 2021). Research in the *Citizen Science Theory and Practice Journal* by Hart and colleagues (2022) further emphasizes this point by highlighting the importance of integrating behavioral science and marketing strategies into volunteer engagement (Hart et al., 2022).

Given that the studies above consistently show how effective volunteer recruitment depend on understanding volunteers and their motivations, the following recruitment and retention strategies have been developed.

Recruitment Phase Strategies

1. Identity-Based Recruitment

Persuade people from joining through emotional, so informing volunteers how their contributions can help ecosystems, animals, etc. Also, initial interest in the environment, climate, and outdoors.

2. Experience-Centered

Meeting new people and exposure to the environment. Allowing members to take roles that they would like to take and have interests for can help gather more volunteers.

3. Career and Skill Development Positioning

Many individuals are motivated to volunteer when the opportunity aligns with their personal or career goals. Demonstrating how a role supports professional development, such as gaining relevant experience and building skills, can increase interest and commitment. Clearly illustrating the skills volunteers can develop may also attract new participants. Even though research suggests career advancement is often a lower priority, it remains a significant factor in influencing decisions to volunteer.

Retention Phase Strategies

1. Reinforcing Enhancement Values

Volunteers stay when they feel personally fulfilled and connected to the cause. Sharing measurable impacts, such as collected cigarette litter for the Butt Blitz, reinforces meaning and encourages continued participation among volunteers.

2. Positive First Experience and Support

Volunteers are motivated by the experience itself, such as social connection, outdoor engagement, and the feeling of making a meaningful contribution. Outlining roles, expectations, and the differences the volunteers will increase their commitment.

3. Learning and Development Opportunities

Providing pathways for growth strengthens commitment and long-term engagement of volunteers, as research shows those with enhancement reasonings are likely to stay (Newton et al., 2014). While not the highest priority for volunteers signing up, emphasizing skills is still a significant factor in attracting volunteers.

References

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- Newton, C., Becker, K., & Bell, S. (2014). Learning and development opportunities as a tool for the retention of volunteers: a motivational perspective. *Human Resource Management Journal*, 24(4), 514–530. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1748-8583.12040>